Kythoria — General Knowledge

> What every common citizen of Kythoria knows about the world they live in.

The World

- The world is called **Aetris**.
- Aetris has three known continents. Kythoria is the only one most people know anything about.
- Kythoria spans from frozen northern wastes to subtropical southern coasts.
- The safest, most populated region is the **temperate heartlands** near the center-southeast, where the three capital cities stand.

The Three Eras of History

Era of Foundation (before 400 years ago)

- Six great mortal kingdoms thrived: **Drakhaven** (Humans), **Elyndor** (Elves), **Kazadur** (Dwarves), **Hearthglen** (Halflings), **Everquill** (Gnomes), **Stonefist** (Half-Orcs).
- An overland trade route called **Crassian's Dust Circle** connected all six kingdoms.
- Much of this era is lost — ~70% of pre-invasion records were destroyed.

The Abominable End (400 – 200 years ago)

- ~400 years ago, monsters began appearing. Their numbers were endless. Their origin is unknown.
- For two centuries, the mortal races were pushed back. All six kingdoms fell. ~80% of the population perrished.

The Rise of the Mortals (200 years ago – Present)

- ~200 years ago, the survivors made their final stand and founded three capital cities: **Skywatch**, **Emberforge**, and **Weaveheart** — collectively called **the Last Stand**.
- A **magical barrier** was developed in Weaveheart, protecting all three cities. It has held for two centuries and is maintained by Weaveheart's mages.
- From this bastion, the mortal races formed the **First Alliance** and its army, the **Dawn Guard**, and began the **reconquering** of lost territories.
- The First Alliance never disbanded. It evolved into the permanent governing body of the three capitals — the **Council Accord**.

The Last Stand — The Three Capitals

Skywatch (The Lookout)

- The highest-elevated city. Serves as the primary scouting, intelligence, and observation post.
- Home to the **Skywatch War College** (trains fighters, paladins, rangers, officers) and the **Scouts' & Rangers**.

- Ruled by a King advised by the **Council of Eyes** — meritocratic scouts, rangers, and strategists.

Emberforge (The Forge)

- An underground city built beneath a volcanic ash wasteland. Harnesses geothermal heat for industry.
- Produces weapons, armor, tools, and unique alloys. The finest equipment on the continent.
- Home to the **Emberforge Engineering Halls** (trains artificers).
- Ruled by a King advised by the **Forgemaster's Circle** — guild leaders and craft clans.

Weaveheart (The Nexus)

- Built at a convergence of **ley lines** — highways of arcane energy crossing the world. The arcane and research heart of the Last Stand.
- The **magical barrier** protecting all three capitals was developed and is maintained here.
- Home to the **Weaveheart Academy of Arcane Arts** (trains wizards) and the **Grand Athenaeum** (largest library on the continent).
- Ruled by a King advised by the **Arcane Conclave** — wizards, scholars, and arcane researchers.

Governance & Law

- The three kings form the **Council Accord** — the closest thing to a central authority. They meet frequently; any king may invoke a formal council.
- The foundation of all law is the **Survival Code** — five articles: **Life** (no murder), **Suply** (no theft of military resources), **Allegiance** (no treason), **Barrier** (no sabotage of defenses), **Truth** (no false acusations).
- Penalties: labor, exile, or execution.
- Beyond the Survival Code, each settlement governs itself. Laws vary by location.
- Society is **militarized** — every able-bodied citizen is expected to contribute to the reconquering.

The Monster War — Current State

- ~3/4 of the continent has been reconquered. ~1/4 remains under monster control, mostly in the **north-west**.
- The **Western Frontier** is the active war zone. The **Frontier Road** runs from the heartlands into contested territory under heavy guard.
- The monster army was once led by **five great generals**. Three were defeated by the First Alliance. Two vanished and were never found.
- No new monsters have appeared in living memory. Those remaining are the ones already here.
- Not all monsters are invaders. **Native monsters** — dragons, owlbears, griffons, basilisks, manticores, and similar creatures — existed on Kythoria long before the invasion. They are not allied with the planar invaders, though they may compete for territory.

The Recovered Territories

South & East

- Fully reclaimed. Home to thriving towns, farms, and trade.
- Two major ports handle sea trade: a **heavily fortified southeastern port** and an **eastern port**.
- The **northeast mining cluster** (centered on the reclaimed dwarven city of **Kazadur**) produces most currency metals and gemstones. Mining towns are open to all races.

The Northern Frontier

- The **Frostmaw** — an arctic region in the north-east — was never conquered by the monster army. It is held independently by the **Skallfang Clan**, a northern barbarian tribe of monster hunters.

The Four Barbarian Tribes

- Four ancient tribal nations guard Kythoria's borders: **Skallfang Clan** (north), **Jade Wardens** (east), **Sunforged Legion** (south), **Tidebound Brotherhood** (west).
- Each developed independently. They are not unified under a single command, but share mutual respect forged by centuries of war.
- All four contributed warriors to the First Alliance.

Races & Ancestries

The Common Races

- **Humans** — Most populous. Created by Aloria, goddess of light and life. Adaptable, ambitious, found everywhere.
- **Elves** (High & Wood) — Long-lived (~750 years), nature-attuned. Created by Kaelthor, god of nature and tempest.
- **Dwarves** (Hill & Mountain) — Master crafters and smiths (~350 years). Created by Thalkis, god of forge and arcana.
- **Halflings** — Lucky traders and farmers (~250 years). Created by Crassian, god of wealth and fortune.
- **Gnomes** (Forest & Rock) — Scholars, inventors, law-keepers (~500 years). Created by Aurelius, god of wisdom and justice.
- **Dragonborn** — Proud hunters with draconic heritage (~80 years). Created by Tyra, goddess of hunt and nature.
- **Orcs** — A martial, clan-based people. Created by Vorn, god of war and conquest.
- **Half-Elves** — Natural offspring of Elves and Humans (~200 years). No god claims them directly; they fall between Kaelthor and Aloria.
- **Half-Orcs** — Natural offspring of Orcs and Humans (~75 years). Tainted by association with Vorn.

The Uncommon Races

- **Genasi** (Air, Fire, Water, Earth) — Elemental-touched (~120 years). Created by Vesper, goddess of peace and twilight. Rare but accepted.
- **Drow** — Dark-skinned elves of the Underdark, created by Lolth, the Spider Queen. Sunlight-sensitive. Highly distrusted on the surface. Few walk the surface; most remain in the Underdark.
- **Shadow Elves (Shadar-kai)** — Shadow-attuned elves of the Shadowfell, created by the Raven Queen. Distrusted on the surface. Rare visitors.

- **Tieflings** — Bearers of demonic heritage (~100 years). No god claims them. Their origin is disputed — some say cursed bloodline, some say demonic taint, but nobody knows for certain. Face widespread prejudice as "godless."

The Blamed Races

- Three gods are publicly blamed for the monster invasion: **Lolth**, **the Raven Queen**, and **Vorn**. Their claimed races bear the stigma:
  - **Drow** (Lolth) — Never joined the First Alliance. Viewed with deep suspicion.
  - **Shadow Elves** (Raven Queen) — Fled to the Shadowfell during the invasion. Distrusted.
  - **Half-Orcs** (Vorn, through Orc bloodline) — DID fight in the First Alliance and helped found the Last Stand, yet face discrimination nonetheless. Many despise Vorn for what he's done to their reputation.
- Open worship of the three banned gods is forbidden in Last Stand territories. Their churches operate in secret.

The Ten Gods

#	God	Domains	Claims	Church	Status
1	**Kaelthor**	Nature, Tempest	Elves	Circle of the Wild	Recognized
2	**Aurelius**	Wisdom, Justice	Gnomes	Order of the Scales	Recognized
3	**Vesper**	Peace, Twilight	Genasi	Vigil of the Dusk	Recognized
4	**Aloria**	Light, Life	Humans	Order of the Dawn	Recognized
5	**Tyra**	Hunt, Nature	Dragonborn	Pack of Tyra	Recognized
6	**Raven Queen**	Death, Grave	Shadow Elves	Order of the Raven	**Banned**
7	**Thalkis**	Forge, Arcana	Dwarves	Guild of the Spark	Recognized
8	**Crassian**	Wealth, Fortune	Halflings	Order of the Currency	Recognized
9	**Vorn**	War, Conquest	Orcs	Iron Host	**Banned**
10	**Lolth**	Trickery, War	Drow	Coven of the Spider	**Banned**

The Public Creation Myth

The gods created the world in this order: Kaelthor shaped the world from chaos → Aurelius imposed law → Vesper set boundaries → Aloria brought light and life → Tyra instilled hunger and survival → Raven Queen completed the cycle with death → Thalkis taught craft and magic → Crassian invented trade → Vorn granted war → Lolth provided cunning.

The Ecumenical Council

- An interfaith council representing the seven recognized churches. It mediates disputes, coordinates festivals, and maintains religious unity.
- The three banned churches have no seat. Their clergy operate in shadows.

The Calendar

- **200 days** per year. **10 months** (named after the gods, in creation order). **2 weeks** per month. **10-day weeks**.
- **Weekdays**: Wildtide, Lawrest, Duskfall, Life-dawn, Fangrest, Gravefall, Sparktide, Cointide, Warmorn, Shadowrest.
- The calendar has existed for ~500 years, established by the first mortal kingdoms.

Month	God	Festival (Day)
1. Kaelthor	Kaelthor	Harvest Communion — feast, thanks (Day 1)
2. Aurelius	Aurelius	The Weighing — legal amnesty, oath-renewal (Day 2)
3. Vesper	Vesper	The Dusk Chime — hour of silence at sunset (Day 3)
4. Aloria	Aloria	Sun rise Rekindling — grand illumination (Day 4)
5. Tyra	Tyra	The Great Hunt — hunting competition (Day 5)
6. Raven Queen	Raven Queen	The Lantern Vigil — paper lanterns for the dead (Day 6)
7. Thalkis	Thalkis	The Great Forging — craft fair, invention (Day 7)
8. Crassian	Crassian	Fortune's Gamble — markets, gambling (Day 8)
9. Vorn	Vorn	The Bloody Standard — war games, parades (Day 9)
10. Lolth	Lolth	Night of Whispers — shadowed deals (Day 10)

- **Day of Silence** (last day, Day 200): Secular. No work, no magic. Quiet reflection honoring the dead.

The Arcane Weave

- Magic comes from the **Arcane Weave** — a permeating field of energy that exists across the world. Its origin is unknown.
- **Ley lines** are highways of concentrated arcane energy crossing the world. Magic is stronger near their convergences (like Weaveheart).
- Spellcasters access the Weave through study (wizards), innate talent (sorcerers), divine channeling (clerics, paladins) or nature attunement (druids, rangers).

Class Training Institutions

Institution	Location	Trains
Weaveheart Academy of Arcane Arts	Weaveheart	Wizards, Sorcerers, Bards
Skywatch War College	Skywatch	Fighters, Paladins, Rangers, Officers
Emberforge Engineering Halls	Emberforge	Artificers
Church Seminaries	All capitals	Clerics, Paladins

Institution	Location	Trains
Guiding Hand	Skywatch	Rangers, Rogues (scout path)

Drakh Ix'thar — The Adventurers' Guild

- "The Great Dragon Hunt" in Draconic. Continent-wide guild. Members are called **Ix'thari**.
- Founded before the invasion, survived the Abominable End, re-established during the reconquering.
- Headquarters in **Drakhaven** (the pre-invasion Human capital at the continent's center), with chapter houses in every major settlement.
- Functions: contract broker (monster hunting, ruin delving, frontier scouting), licensing, intelligence network, support.
- Ranks are named in Draconic after legendary beasts. Highest: **Drah Ix'thari** (Dragon Hunter).
- Adventurers are highly respected — seen as guardians, cleansers, and reclaimers, not mere mercenaries.

Economy & Trade

- **Currency**: Copper, silver, gold, and platinum pieces. Minted in **Hearthglen** (the Halfling kingdom's historic mint, now resumed).
- **Major industries**: Mining (northeast cluster), smithing (Emberforge), agriculture (fertile forests around the capitals — the soil is exceptionally rich), arcane research and enchanted goods (Weaveheart, House Thormvuld), monster hunting (Drakh Ix'thar), sea trade (southeastern and eastern ports).
- **Trade routes**: The **Eastern Sea Route** (coastal shipping) and **Crassian's Dust Circle** (ancient overland route, restored, connects all major settlements).
- **House Thormvuld**: A dwarven arcane engineering family, the premier magical item producers on the continent. They recently constructed a **floating estate called Seidga'ard** using newly discovered magical crystals.
- **Monster parts economy**: An emerging industry — venoms, hides, scales, bones, and organs used in alchemy, crafting, and arcane research.

The Dark Alliance

- A recently formed political pact between the **Drow of the Underdark** and the **Shadow Elves of the Shadowfell**. Its goals and implications are not yet widely understood.

Culture & Society

- **Core values**: Unity ("divided we fight, united we stand"), resilience, contribution (everyone does their part), curiosity (recovering lost knowledge), faith.
- **Death & memory**: Memory shrines — candles lit for fallen loved ones. Death is close; life is celebrated grandly.
- **Education**: Public academies (ages 6–12), then apprenticeship or military service (12–18). Higher education at Weaveheart Academy or Skywatch War College.
- **Arts**: Skywatch Chorus (festival choir), Emberforge Operas (smithing + fire + drama), Weaveheart Illuminations (magical light shows).

- **Social standing**: Earned through concrete contributions to the reconquering — monsters slain, territory reclaimed, communities protected. No rigid caste system.

Key Settlements Beyond the Capitals

Settlement	Region	Notes
Drakhaven	Center	Pre-invasion Human capital. Largest and most advanced city of its time. Partially reclaimed. Home to Drakh Ix'thar HQ and the High Septon (main temple of Aurelius).
Kazadur	Northeast	Former Dwarven capital. Its mines produced the continent's currency metals and gemstones. Partially reclaimed; mining resumed.
Hearthglen	Center-east?	Former Halfling capital. Home of the royal mint. Destroyed during the invasion; mint operations have resumed in reclaimed halfling communities.
The Southeestern Port	Southeast	Heavily fortified coastal trade hub. Exports exotic goods from the south.
The Eastern Port	East	Key waypoint on the Eastern Sea Route.
The Underdark	South-west	A sunken forest of perpetual shadow beneath a colossal Black Willow. Home of the Drow.
The Frostmaw	North-east	Arctic homeland of the Skallfang Clan. Never conquered by the monster army.
The Frontier	West	Contested zone. Forward operating bases, palisaded settlements, ruins, and dungeons. Where the reconquering happens.